

DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE & BUSINESS SYSTEMS

U21CB601

DIGITAL MARKETING AND ANALYTICS

Assignment 2

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Submitted By

Sharvesh S

Roll No: 23CB053

Question 1 | Improving Backlink Profile Using Open Site Explorer

1.1 Introduction to Backlinks and SEO

Backlinks — also called inbound links or incoming links — are hyperlinks from external websites pointing to your domain. Search engines like Google use backlinks as a major ranking signal: a site with many high-quality backlinks is perceived as authoritative and trustworthy. However, not all backlinks are equal. A single link from a DA-90 news portal can outweigh hundreds of links from low-quality directories. This is why systematic analysis using dedicated tools is essential.

1.2 What Is Open Site Explorer (OSE)?

Open Site Explorer, developed by Moz, is a comprehensive backlink research tool that allows digital marketers to audit their own backlink profile and investigate competitors. It provides critical metrics including Domain Authority (DA), Page Authority (PA), anchor text distribution, linking root domains, and spam score.

1.3 Key Metrics Provided by OSE

Metric	What It Tells You
Domain Authority (DA)	A 1–100 score predicting how well a domain ranks on search engines
Page Authority (PA)	Predictive score for individual page ranking potential
Linking Root Domains	Number of unique domains linking to your site (diversity matters)
Anchor Text Distribution	Keywords used in backlinks — over-optimized anchors trigger penalties
Spam Score	% of linking sites with spam-like characteristics — keep this low
Follow vs. NoFollow	Only follow links pass link equity; NoFollow links still drive traffic

1.4 Step-by-Step Application of OSE

Step 1 — Baseline Audit

Enter your domain into OSE. Note your current DA, total inbound links, and linking root domains. For example, an e-commerce startup, ShopEasy.com, may have DA 28 with 340 linking domains — a reasonable baseline for a 2-year-old site.

Step 2 — Competitor Gap Analysis

Enter 3–5 competitor domains. Suppose a competitor, TrendCart.com, has DA 55 with 1,200 linking domains. OSE's 'Compare Link Metrics' feature reveals which domains link to TrendCart but not to ShopEasy — these are your link acquisition targets.

Step 3 — Anchor Text Analysis

OSE's anchor text report shows how external sites describe your page. A healthy profile has a mix: branded anchors (e.g., 'ShopEasy'), generic anchors ('click here'), and a minority of keyword-rich anchors ('buy shoes online'). If 80% of anchors use one exact keyword, Google's Penguin algorithm may flag this as manipulative.

Step 4 — Toxic Link Detection

OSE flags domains with a spam score above 30%. For ShopEasy, suppose OSE identifies 45 links from link farms and PBNs (Private Blog Networks). These should be submitted to Google's Disavow Tool to prevent negative SEO impact.

1.5 Strategies to Improve Backlink Profile

- Guest Blogging on High-DA Sites: Publish valuable articles on industry blogs (DA 50+) with natural anchor links back to your domain.
- Broken Link Building: Use OSE to find broken links on competitor-referencing pages, then offer your content as a replacement.
- HARO (Help a Reporter Out): Answer journalist queries to earn editorial backlinks from news portals like Forbes and Inc.
- Digital PR & Infographics: Create shareable visual content that authoritative sites naturally link to.
- Disavow Toxic Links: Regularly audit and disavow spammy inbound links using Google Search Console.

1.6 Real-World Example — Case Study

Brand	Zappos.com (Footwear E-commerce)
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Strategy	Zappos systematically identified DA 70+ fashion blogs through OSE and executed 200+ guest posts over 18 months. They diversified anchors and built relationships with editorial teams.
Result	DA improved from 62 to 78. Organic traffic increased by 43%. Keyword rankings for high-intent terms like 'buy boots online' moved from page 3 to page 1.

1.7 Analysis & Conclusion

Open Site Explorer transforms backlink auditing from guesswork into data-driven strategy. By continuously monitoring DA growth, anchor diversity, linking domain quality, and spam scores, digital marketers can build a robust, penalty-resistant backlink profile that directly translates into higher organic rankings and increased website traffic.

Question 2 | Using WHOIS and Domain Tools for Smart Domain Acquisition

2.1 Introduction to Domain Decision-Making

Choosing the right domain name is one of the most consequential decisions a business makes online. A domain that appears available could carry hidden baggage — past spam penalties, trademark conflicts, or expired backlink profiles. WHOIS and domain intelligence tools provide the data needed to make an informed purchase.

2.2 What Is WHOIS?

WHOIS is a public protocol that queries domain registration databases maintained by ICANN-accredited registrars. When a domain is registered, information including the registrant's name, organization, email, phone, registrar name, registration date, expiry date, and nameservers is stored. Tools like DomainTools, ViewDNS, and ICANN WHOIS provide a clean interface to retrieve this data.

2.3 Key Insights from WHOIS & Domain Tools

Data Point	Business Significance
Registration Date	Older domains often have more SEO authority; aged domains are preferred
Expiry Date	Reveals if the domain is expiring soon — ideal for acquisition opportunity
Registrant History	Exposes previous owners and their reputation or spam history
Domain Age	Google tends to trust older domains more than newly registered ones
Historical Blacklists	Shows if the domain was penalized by Google or blacklisted for spam/phishing
Previous Content (Archive)	Wayback Machine reveals what content the domain hosted — critical for brand safety

2.4 Risk Avoidance — What to Check

Trademark Conflicts

Before buying 'AppleTech.com', check the USPTO trademark database. If 'AppleTech' is a registered trademark in your industry, you risk a UDRP (Uniform Domain-Name Dispute-Resolution Policy) lawsuit

from the trademark holder. Tools like Trademarkia integrate with domain search platforms to flag this instantly.

Google Penalty History

Use Moz’s spam score check and the Wayback Machine to investigate whether the previous owner used the domain for link spam, doorway pages, or phishing. A domain that was deindexed by Google may take 12–18 months to regain trust even after clean content is published.

Backlink Profile of Expired Domains

Expired domains with strong, clean backlink profiles are valuable assets. Use Ahrefs or Open Site Explorer to check the domain's incoming links. A domain like 'VintageWatches.com' expiring with 500 links from luxury lifestyle blogs can jumpstart a new brand's SEO.

2.5 Practical Domain Evaluation Framework

Evaluation Criterion	Weight	Tool to Use
Domain Age & History	High	WHOIS, DomainTools
Spam & Penalty Check	Critical	Moz Spam Score, Google Search Console
Backlink Profile Quality	High	Ahrefs, Open Site Explorer
Trademark Clearance	Critical	USPTO, Trademarkia
Previous Content Review	Medium	Wayback Machine (Archive.org)
Brand Alignment & Memorability	High	Manual + Brand Testing

2.6 Real-World Example

A fintech startup sought to acquire 'QuickLoans.in'. WHOIS data revealed the domain was previously owned by a blacklisted NBFC that Google had deindexed for cloaking. The Wayback Machine showed pages full of misleading loan offers. Despite an attractive DA of 35, the startup correctly avoided purchase and instead registered a fresh domain, 'SwiftCredit.in', avoiding both SEO and reputational risk.

2.7 Conclusion

WHOIS and domain intelligence tools act as a due-diligence layer before any domain investment. By verifying age, ownership history, penalty status, trademark safety, and backlink quality, businesses can make confident, risk-free domain decisions that support long-term brand integrity and SEO growth.

Question 3 | Social Media Lead Generation — Diagnosing a Failing Strategy

3.1 The Followers vs. Leads Paradox

A growing social media following feels like success, but followers and leads are fundamentally different metrics. Followers represent reach; leads represent revenue potential. A startup may amass 50,000 Instagram followers yet generate fewer than 100 qualified leads per month. This disconnect signals a broken conversion funnel, not a content strategy problem.

3.2 Why the Current Strategy Is Failing

Reason 1 — Brand Awareness Content Without CTAs

If the majority of posts are motivational quotes, product aesthetics, or viral memes, followers engage (likes, shares) but have no clear next step. Without a compelling Call-To-Action (CTA) — 'Download our free guide', 'Book a free demo', 'Claim your 20% discount' — engagement remains superficial.

Reason 2 — Wrong Audience Targeting

A SaaS startup targeting 'entrepreneurs' on Facebook may attract curious students and job seekers rather than decision-makers with purchasing authority. Broad targeting inflates follower numbers but reduces lead quality. Facebook's Audience Insights often reveals that 60%+ of followers in such campaigns fall outside the buyer persona.

Reason 3 — No Lead Capture Mechanism

Driving traffic to a generic homepage instead of a dedicated landing page with a lead capture form is one of the most common and costly mistakes. Visitors who land on a cluttered homepage face too many choices and typically leave without converting.

Reason 4 — Inconsistent Nurturing

Social media lead generation is not a one-touch process. Research shows that 80% of sales require at least five follow-up touches. Brands that post twice a week and then go silent for two weeks lose momentum and prospect trust.

3.3 Effective Social Media Lead Generation Techniques

Technique	Application Example
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Lead Generation Ads (Facebook/Instagram)	A coaching brand runs an ad offering a free PDF guide. Users click, fill a native lead form — no website redirect needed.
LinkedIn Lead Gen Forms	A B2B software company promotes a webinar on LinkedIn. Professionals register directly without leaving the platform.
Social Media Giveaways	Require email submission for contest entry; builds a list while boosting reach organically.
Interactive Stories & Polls	Instagram stories with 'Swipe Up' or link stickers drive traffic to landing pages with lead magnets.
Retargeting Campaigns	Pixel-based retargeting re-engages users who visited but did not convert, increasing lead conversion rates by up to 70%.
Chatbot Lead Capture	ManyChat or MobileMonkey bots on Facebook Messenger qualify leads through automated Q&A sequences.

3.4 The AIDA–Lead Funnel Model for Social Media

Mapping social content to the AIDA (Awareness–Interest–Desire–Action) framework creates a structured lead funnel:

- Awareness Stage: Educational posts, infographics, and viral content to attract new followers.
- Interest Stage: Case studies, testimonials, and behind-the-scenes content to build trust.
- Desire Stage: Limited-time offers, free trials, and comparison posts to create urgency.
- Action Stage: Strong CTA posts, lead gen ads, and chatbot sequences to capture information.

3.5 Real-World Example — HubSpot

HubSpot mastered social media lead generation by offering free marketing tools and educational content (blogs, webinars, certifications) as lead magnets. Their LinkedIn lead gen forms for webinar registrations consistently convert at 8–12%, compared to the industry average of 2–3%. By mapping every piece of social content to a specific funnel stage and CTA, HubSpot turned social media from a brand awareness channel into their primary inbound lead generation engine.

3.6 Conclusion

Social media lead generation requires intentional funnel design, precise audience targeting, compelling lead magnets, and relentless nurturing. A high follower count without a systematic lead capture mechanism is merely vanity — transforming it into a revenue-generating asset demands strategic alignment between content, audience, and conversion pathways.

Question 4 | Reducing High CPC and Improving Paid Campaign ROI

4.1 Understanding CPC and ROI in Digital Advertising

Cost Per Click (CPC) is the amount an advertiser pays each time a user clicks on a paid ad. While high CPC does not automatically mean poor performance, an unsustainably high CPC combined with low conversion rates creates negative ROI — the advertiser spends more acquiring a customer than the customer is worth (LTV). Addressing this requires diagnosing both the ad auction dynamics and on-site conversion performance.

4.2 Root Causes of High CPC

1. Broad and Non-Specific Keywords

Bidding on broad-match keywords like 'shoes' or 'software' places your ads in highly competitive auctions. Google's auction model means popular keywords attract dozens of bidders, inflating CPC. An e-commerce brand bidding on 'running shoes' may pay INR 120 per click, while 'women's lightweight trail running shoes' may cost INR 28 with higher purchase intent.

2. Low Quality Score

Google Ads assigns a Quality Score (1–10) to each keyword based on expected CTR, ad relevance, and landing page experience. A QS of 3 can increase your CPC by up to 50% compared to competitors with QS 8. Irrelevant ad copy, generic landing pages, and poor historical CTR all depress Quality Score.

3. Poor Ad Scheduling and Geographic Targeting

Running ads 24/7 in all geographies wastes budget during low-conversion windows. An Indian B2B SaaS company targeting decision-makers should restrict ads to working hours (9AM–7PM) and Tier-1 cities. Ads running at 2AM or in non-target regions inflate impressions without conversions, wasting budget.

4. Ad Fatigue

When the same audience sees the same ad repeatedly, CTR drops and CPC rises. Facebook's frequency metric is a key indicator — a frequency above 3–4 in a tight audience signals ad fatigue.

4.3 Strategies to Reduce CPC

Strategy	Expected CPC Reduction
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Long-Tail Keyword Targeting	30–60% reduction in competitive keywords
Improve Quality Score (QS)	A QS improvement from 5 to 8 can reduce CPC by 28%
Negative Keywords List	Eliminates irrelevant clicks; reduces wasted spend by 15–25%
Ad Scheduling Optimization	10–20% improvement in budget efficiency
Audience Segmentation & Retargeting	Retargeted ads convert 3–5x better at lower CPC
Dynamic Keyword Insertion (DKI)	Boosts CTR by 10–15%, improving QS and reducing CPC

4.4 Improving Landing Page Quality for Better ROI

Reducing CPC is only half the equation. If the landing page fails to convert visitors, ROI remains negative. Key improvements include:

- Above-the-Fold Value Proposition: Clearly state what the user gets and why it matters within 5 seconds.
- Mobile-First Design: 68% of paid traffic arrives via mobile. A non-responsive page can waste 60%+ of ad spend.
- Single CTA per Page: Multiple CTAs create decision paralysis. One clear button — 'Start Free Trial' or 'Get My Quote' — maximizes conversions.
- Speed Optimization: Pages loading in under 2 seconds convert 3x better than pages taking 5+ seconds.

4.5 Case Study — Freshworks

Problem	Freshworks India was spending INR 18 lakhs/month on Google Ads with CPC of INR 340 for 'CRM software' keywords and a 1.2% conversion rate.
Solution	They shifted budget to long-tail keywords ('affordable CRM for small teams India'), added 200+ negative keywords, rebuilt landing pages with personalized CTAs per ad group, and implemented bid adjustments for mobile and timing.
Result	CPC dropped from INR 340 to INR 147. Conversion rate improved from 1.2% to 3.8%. Total leads increased by 190% with the same budget. ROI turned positive within 45 days.

4.6 Conclusion

High CPC is rarely a single-cause problem — it is the cumulative result of broad targeting, poor Quality Scores, irrelevant audiences, and weak landing pages. A holistic optimization approach combining keyword precision, Quality Score improvement, intelligent scheduling, and conversion-focused landing pages creates a compounding improvement in campaign ROI.

Question 5 | Ethical Group Posting Strategies to Avoid Blocks & Generate Leads

5.1 Why Group Posting Gets Blocked

Social media groups — on Facebook, LinkedIn, Reddit, and WhatsApp — are community spaces governed by administrators and platform algorithms. Companies that treat them as free advertising boards face swift consequences: content removal, temporary posting restrictions, account suspension, and permanent bans. Understanding why blocks occur is the first step to building an ethical, sustainable group marketing strategy.

5.2 Analysis of What Went Wrong

Issue 1 — Repetitive Promotional Spam

Posting identical promotional content ('Buy our product at 20% off! Link: xyz.com') across 50 groups simultaneously triggers both admin removal and Facebook's spam detection algorithms. The algorithm monitors posting frequency, copy duplication, and link-to-text ratios. A business posting the same content in 10+ groups within one hour is automatically flagged.

Issue 2 — Violating Group Rules

Most groups explicitly prohibit self-promotion, competitor mentions, affiliate links, and external URLs. Businesses that post without reading group rules are removed immediately. LinkedIn Professional groups, for instance, frequently have rules requiring 80% educational content before any promotional post is acceptable.

Issue 3 — Lack of Value Contribution

Arriving in a community exclusively to promote — without answering questions, sharing insights, or contributing to discussions — marks a poster as a lurker-promoter. Community members and admins recognize this pattern, leading to social blocking even before the platform algorithm responds.

Issue 4 — Using Automation Tools Unethically

Tools that auto-post, auto-like, or auto-comment across groups violate platform Terms of Service. Facebook's algorithm detects non-human behavioral patterns (consistent posting at 3AM, identical timestamps across groups) and initiates shadow banning or full account suspension.

5.3 Ethical Group Posting Strategy Framework

Ethical Practice	Why It Works
Join Niche-Relevant Groups Only	Smaller, focused groups have higher engagement rates and more qualified members
Read and Follow Group Rules	Demonstrates respect; builds trust with admins who may become advocates
Value-First Content: 80/20 Rule	80% educational/helpful posts, 20% promotional — mirrors community content norms
Engage Before You Promote	Spend 2–4 weeks answering questions and commenting before any self-promotion
Use Soft CTAs	Offer free resources, not hard sell links — 'I wrote a guide on this, DM me for the link'
Build Admin Relationships	Offer to create exclusive content for the group — admins become brand ambassadors

5.4 The GIVE-GIVE-GIVE-ASK Model

Marketing expert Gary Vaynerchuk's 'Jab, Jab, Jab, Right Hook' principle translates directly to group posting:

- GIVE 1: Answer a member's question thoroughly with no promotional intent.
- GIVE 2: Share a free resource, checklist, or tutorial genuinely useful to the group.
- GIVE 3: Contribute a case study or insight that sparks meaningful discussion.
- ASK: After establishing credibility through consistent giving, introduce your product/service in a contextually appropriate, low-pressure way.

This model works because trust is built before the ask. Members who have received value from you are 7x more likely to engage with a promotional post compared to cold promotional content from an unknown brand.

5.5 Platform-Specific Best Practices

Facebook Groups

Use Facebook's 'Member Questions' feature when joining groups — provide genuine answers that showcase expertise. Avoid posting links in the first 30 days of joining a new group. Instead, post engaging text-only questions and discussions to build your member profile.

LinkedIn Groups

LinkedIn groups penalize link-heavy posts in their algorithm. Instead, post native long-form articles with insights related to your industry. Include a soft CTA at the end: 'Happy to share our implementation framework — connect with me directly.' This drives connection requests rather than outbound clicks.

WhatsApp Communities

WhatsApp lead generation works best through permission-based groups you own or co-administer. Create a free resource group ('Daily Marketing Tips'), invite your target audience, and use the community trust to introduce products naturally over time.

5.6 Case Study — Zoho Social

Zoho's marketing team faced repeated Facebook group bans in 2020 when their agency partners posted promotional content aggressively. They restructured their approach: trained agency partners on value-first content protocols, created a 90-day community engagement calendar for each group, and prohibited direct product links in the first 60 days of joining any group.

Results: Zero bans in 18 months. Organic leads from Facebook groups grew from 40/month to 310/month. Community engagement rates increased by 280%. Three group admins became official Zoho advocates.

5.7 Conclusion

Group posting bans are not a platform problem — they are a strategy problem. Ethical group marketing is rooted in community-first thinking: joining relevant spaces, contributing genuine value, building relationships with administrators, and earning the right to promote through consistent helpfulness. When executed with patience and authenticity, social media group marketing becomes one of the highest-ROI, zero-cost lead generation channels available to any business.

End of Assignment

Sharvesh S | 23CB053 | U21CB601 Digital Marketing and Analytics
